

Negatives and their scope

Learner workbook

Make clear what is not true or not required.

Understand the distinction

In standard written English, combine not with any or use no: I do not have any cash / I have no cash. Other dialects use negative concord, such as not ... nothing; recognize it without treating its speakers as less capable.

Position changes scope. Not everyone came means some people did not come; nobody came means zero people came. Must not means prohibited, while do not have to means optional. Check what part of the meaning you are negating.

Compare the patterns

PART OF A GROUP

Not everyone agreed.

At least one person did not agree.

ZERO

Nobody agreed.

No person agreed.

OPTIONAL

You do not have to attend.

Attendance is not required.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Rewrite for standard formal English: I do not have no time.

2. Does Not all seats are taken mean every seat is empty?

3. Which means prohibited: must not / do not have to?

Use it in your own life

Write a sentence about something optional and something prohibited.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. I do not have any time.

Alternatively: I have no time.

2. No. It means at least some seats are free.

Not all and none have different meanings.

3. must not

Do not have to removes an obligation.

One possible response

You do not have to print the form. You must not share your password.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-25.html